

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN GUINEA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is honest that Guinea has no landmark community victory to point to, that mining is the centre of the economy, and that the political ground — a military transition of uncertain direction — is not firm. It is built around the levers that do reach the mines here — the global companies bound by their own standards and reputations, the financiers whose accountability mechanisms communities can petition, the buyers and the "just transition" the metals are sold under, the requirement of genuine consent, and the transition government's scrutiny of the deals — and names each in plain words. Throughout, it puts your safety first.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

In Guinea the destructive force is among the most powerful on earth, because Guinea sits on the ore the world's aluminium and steel are made from. It is one of the world's great mineral nations — the largest or second-largest exporter of **bauxite**, the ore from which aluminium is made, and holder of one of the planet's largest, richest untapped high-grade **iron-ore** deposits. In the **Boké region**, vast open-pit bauxite mines run by international consortia have **expropriated ancestral farmland, polluted and cut off water sources, choked villages with dust** from endless mining lorries, and left whole communities without the land they lived on — and a government study projects that within two decades bauxite mining will destroy tens of thousands of hectares of farmland and hundreds of thousands of hectares of natural habitat. Now a giant iron-ore project deep in the southeastern rainforest, with a new four-hundred-mile railway and port, is coming online.

A community in Guinea works with real, if indirect, levers — and the distinctive truth is that they run far beyond the mine, back through the global supply chain the ore flows into. Major mining companies operate under **their own human-rights and environmental standards** and are sensitive to **reputation**. Their **international financiers** — development banks and lenders — run **accountability mechanisms** communities can petition. The **buyers** of the metal, and the "just transition" it is branded under, care about clean supply chains. Guinean law requires **consent and consultation** and provides for **compensation and environmental assessment**. And the **transition government** has, at times, scrutinised the mining deals. Ore that flows out to the world's most reputation-conscious industries can be pressed back through them. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. **Mining is the nation's economic lifeblood** and revenue, so the state is deeply committed to the mines and to expanding them. The **companies are among the largest in the world** and carried on regardless of a coup. The affected **communities are poor and often hope for the jobs** mining might bring, so they are not always united. The country is under a **military transition of uncertain direction, with civil-society space constrained** — so caution and safety come first. And there is **no landmark victory** to point to. So aim for what these levers can deliver, insisting that the metals the world needs not be dug from the ruin of communities' land and lives.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A mine looks unstoppable, but it depends on a chain that reaches around the world, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A Guinean fight turns on the **companies' own standards and reputations**; on the

financiers' accountability mechanisms; on the **buyers and the "just transition" branding**; on the **requirement of consent** and the compensation and assessment law; and on the **transition government's scrutiny**. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and the global supply chain runs through them all, far beyond a mining-dependent state's reach. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull — safely.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you begin — and mind your safety in a constrained space — work out your real situation:

- **If a global company runs the mine, its own standards and reputation are levers** — it does not want to be exposed abusing them.
- **If international lenders finance it, their accountability mechanisms are a real route** — communities can petition them directly.
- **If the metal is sold as "clean" or feeding the green transition, that branding is a pressure point** — buyers fear a supply chain dug from ruin.
- **If the state and the companies are powerful and the space constrained, don't rely on confrontation** — reach the supply chain, insist on consent and compensation, and put safety first; and know the community may not be united, since many hope for jobs.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **reach beyond the mine to the companies' standards, the financiers, and the buyers**, and **insist on genuine consent and fair compensation** — the levers a globally-traded ore offers. Do it carefully, safely, in a constrained space.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

The mines are run by **international consortia** under mining agreements with the state, which is deeply committed to the revenue. The companies operate under **their own human-rights and environmental standards** and are sensitive to **reputation**. Their **international financiers** run **accountability mechanisms**. The **buyers** and the "just transition" branding care about clean supply. Guinean law requires **consent, consultation, compensation, and environmental assessment**. And the **transition government** has at times scrutinised the deals. Know which of these you can reach — the supply chain is the sharpest, the state the least movable.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The mining agreement and assessment. The project needs its agreement, environmental assessment, and consultation. *Your opening:* insist on **genuine consent and consultation**, and attack a defective assessment.

The company standards. *Your opening:* a documented abuse breaches the company's own human-rights and environmental standards, and its reputation.

The financiers. *Your opening — a real route:* petition the financiers' **accountability mechanisms** over harm and lack of consent.

The buyers and the transition. *Your opening:* reach the buyers and the "just transition" branding, and the transition government's scrutiny of the deals.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who runs it and who finances it** — the international consortium and its lenders, because both are bound by standards and reputations you can reach. **What standards and commitments it's bound by** — the company's human-rights and environmental policies, the financiers' safeguards, the "clean supply" branding — because a documented breach is your lever. **What consent and compensation are owed** — because these are your legal and moral claims.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **companies' own standards** and their **reputations**. The **financiers' accountability mechanisms**. The **buyers** and the "just transition" branding. Guinean **consent, compensation, and assessment law**. The **transition government's scrutiny**. And Guinea's — and the world's — **environmental and human-rights organisations, international watchdogs, and press** are the forces that reach furthest, carrying a community's case up the global supply chain.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises, and there is no landmark win here. What most moves them: whether you can reach the supply chain and financiers, whether consent and harm can be documented, and how constrained the space is.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost/Risk	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Insist on consent + consultation	20–45%	months	low	Consent honoured; project reshaped
Claim fair compensation	25–50%	months–yr	low	Compensation paid or improved
Company-standards / reputation pressure	25–50%	months–yr	low	Abuse curbed; company responds
Financiers' accountability mechanism	30–55%	months–2 yr	low	Investigation; harm addressed
Buyers / "just transition" branding	25–50%	months–yr	low	Supply-chain pressure on the company
Transition-government scrutiny	20–45%	months–yr	low–risk	A deal reviewed or conditioned
International watchdogs + press	30–55%	months–yr	low	Global exposure of the harm
Everything together (supply chain, financiers, consent)	30–55%	months–2 yr	mod	Harm reduced; consent/compensation forced
Direct confrontation with the state/company	5–20%	—	high risk	Often ineffective and dangerous

The levers that move the needle most are the **financiers' accountability mechanisms**, the **company standards and reputation**, and the **buyers / "just transition" branding**, backed by **insistence on consent and compensation** and **international watchdogs**. There's no landmark ceiling to cite — the honest floor is a mining-dependent state, powerful companies, poor and divided communities, and a

constrained, uncertain political space. So aim for consent and compensation honoured, harm reduced, water and farmland protected, a deal scrutinised, and accountability forced.

On cost and risk: reaching the supply chain, petitioning financiers, and documenting harm are low-cost; but direct confrontation in a constrained space carries real risk. The great strength is that the ore flows to reputation-conscious industries reachable from far away; the great requirements are to reach up the supply chain rather than only at the mine, and to keep your people safe.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the mine" is weak. Being specific — this financier, this company standard, this missing consent — is strong. Answer five questions in writing, carefully.

- 1. Who runs it and who finances it?** Name the consortium, its parent companies, and its **international lenders** — because both companies and financiers are bound by standards and reputations you can reach.
- 2. What does it take and harm?** Document the **farmland expropriated, the water polluted or cut off, the dust, the habitat lost** — and, for the community, the food security and livelihood at stake.
- 3. What standards, commitments, and consent bind it?** The company's human-rights and environmental policies, the financiers' safeguards, the "clean supply" branding, and the **consent, consultation, and compensation** Guinean law requires. **A documented breach of these is your sharpest lever.**
- 4. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline?** Is an agreement, assessment, or consultation in process? Is compensation owed or unpaid? Is a financier's decision pending? These openings matter.
- 5. Is the community united, who's affected, and who's at risk?** The affected villages, neighbouring communities, and — carefully, in a constrained space — organisations and watchdogs. Be honest that many hope for jobs, and mind everyone's safety.

What this looks like in real life. A bauxite mine expropriates a community's farmland and fouls its water, run by an international consortium with international lenders, the metal sold as feeding the green transition. The five questions yield: the consortium and its financiers; the harm to farmland and water (the claim); the standards, consent, and compensation it breaches (the lever); a financier or consultation in play; and a community, some hoping for jobs, to unite carefully. That's the Guinean pattern — insist on consent and compensation, document the breach, and reach up the supply chain to the company, the financiers, and the buyers.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can press the supply chain and one that can't is documented proof of harm and breach. Build it in three layers, carefully.

Layer one: the harm. Document the **farmland taken, the water polluted or cut off, the dust, the habitat lost**, and the harm to livelihood and food security — with dated, located photographs, testimony, and, where possible, water and health evidence. This is the human core of every claim.

Layer two: the standards, consent, and compensation. Get the company's **human-rights and environmental standards**, the financiers' **safeguards**, the "clean supply" commitments, and the record of **consent, consultation, and compensation** (or their absence). Identify the **documented breach** — the

gap between what they promised and what they did.

Layer three: the supply-chain map. Trace the ore from the mine to its **financiers and buyers**, so you know whom to reach and how the harm breaches their commitments. Walking into a financier's accountability mechanism, a company, the buyers, or the international press with documented harm and a documented breach is what makes them act.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The harm** — farmland, water, dust, habitat, livelihood — with dated photographs, testimony, and water/health evidence.
- **The company standards, financier safeguards, and "clean supply" commitments** — from the companies' and lenders' own materials.
- **The consent, consultation, and compensation record** — or its absence.
- **The supply-chain map** — the mine, its financiers, its buyers.
- **The documented breach** — the gap between commitment and conduct — gathered with care for safety.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a community that reaches up the supply chain — carefully, and as united as it can be — gives you leverage a mining state cannot block. Build in four moves, safely.

Root it in the affected community — honestly. Start with those whose farmland and water are taken, and be honest that many hope for jobs. Frame the fight as **consent, fair compensation, and harm reduced** — not necessarily stopping all mining — so you hold as much unity as you can.

Bring in organisations and experts — carefully. Enlist environmental and human-rights organisations, watchdogs, and experts who can document the harm and reach the financiers and buyers — mindful of the constrained space and everyone's safety.

Reach up the supply chain. The distinctive Guinean lever: take the documented harm and breach to the **company's standards and reputation, the financiers' accountability mechanisms, and the buyers and "just transition" branding** — the reputation-conscious industries the ore flows to, reachable from far beyond the mine.

Build to last, and put safety first. In a constrained, uncertain space, build careful roles, a secure archive, an honest way to decide, and — above all — a **safety plan** for those exposed. Avoid needless confrontation; the supply-chain route is both safer and often more effective.

STEP 4: THE SUPPLY CHAIN, THE FINANCIERS & CONSENT

Guinea's sharpest levers reach beyond the mine — to the companies, the financiers, and the buyers — anchored in the requirement of consent.

Consent, Consultation, and Compensation

Start with your rights: Guinean law requires **consent and consultation** and provides for **compensation** and **environmental assessment**. Insist on **genuine consent** (not manufactured), demand **fair**

compensation, and attack a defective assessment. Documented failures here ground every supply-chain claim.

The Company Standards and Reputation

Major mining companies operate under **their own human-rights and environmental standards** and are sensitive to **reputation**. A documented breach — land taken without consent, water fouled — can be pressed against the company's own commitments and its public image, which it does not want tarnished.

The Financiers' Accountability Mechanisms

A real, distinctive route: the mines' **international financiers** (development banks and lenders) run **accountability mechanisms** that communities can **petition directly** over harm and lack of consent. These can trigger investigations and require the harm to be addressed — a lever that reaches the mine from the world of finance.

The Buyers and the "Just Transition"

The metal is sold into global supply chains and branded as feeding the **clean-energy transition**. Reach the **buyers** and challenge the "just transition" branding: a supply chain dug from the ruin of communities is a reputational risk they will press the company to fix.

The Honest Limits — and Safety

Straight talk: these levers are real but indirect, the state and companies are powerful, communities are poor and divided, the space is constrained, and there's no landmark win. Direct confrontation carries real risk. So use the supply-chain, financier, and consent levers — carefully, safely — and count consent and compensation honoured, harm reduced, water and farmland protected, a deal scrutinised, and accountability forced as real wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Harm becomes a breach of the company's own promises. Not "the mine is bad" but *"they took our farmland and fouled our water — a breach of the company's own human-rights and environmental standards."*

Lack of consent becomes a financier's concern. *"There was no genuine consent — a breach of the safeguards the lenders require, which we will petition."*

"Clean" metal becomes a supply-chain risk. *"This ore is sold as feeding the green transition — but it's dug from the ruin of our land, a supply chain the buyers should not want."*

Unpaid compensation becomes a claim. *"The compensation the law requires was never fairly paid."*

Match it to the venue: the harm and breach to the company's standards and the press; the lack of consent to the financiers' mechanisms; the "clean" branding to the buyers; the compensation to the law and the company. Keep it careful and safe.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Guinea, international attention is the distinctive lever, because the ore flows to reputation-conscious global industries — and a supply chain exposed as dug from ruin is a risk the companies, financiers, and buyers will move to fix. International watchdogs and press make the media front reach far. But in a constrained space, care and safety come first.

Lead with the harm and the global supply chain, not procedure. Not "the assessment was deficient" but "the aluminium and 'green' metal the world buys is dug from the farmland and water of communities left with nothing." Use your strongest material: the documented harm, dated photographs, testimony, and the breach of the companies' own commitments.

Work several audiences at once — reach the world. Careful domestic attention where safe; and above all international watchdogs, the financiers, the buyers, and the global press, where the reputation-conscious supply chain is most exposed. Make it easy: captioned photos, accurate summaries, a supply-chain map, careful testimony.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit hard-won proof. And protect people — in a constrained space, carry the fight carefully, prioritise the international and supply-chain route over risky confrontation, and safeguard those exposed.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything; and mind your safety.

8A — Insisting on consent / consultation (to the company / authority).

Subject: Consent and consultation — [mine/project] at [location].

"We, the community of [place], record that we have not given genuine consent to [mine/project] on our land, and demand the consultation and consent the law requires. [Contact.]"

8B — Claiming compensation.

Subject: Compensation for [land/water] taken — [mine].

"We, the community of [place], claim the fair compensation the law requires for [farmland expropriated / water cut off / harm done] by [mine]. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — To the company (its own standards).

Subject: Breach of your standards — [mine] at [location].

"We, the community of [place], document that [mine] has [taken our farmland without consent / fouled our water], in breach of your own human-rights and environmental standards. We ask you to remedy it. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — Petition to a financier's accountability mechanism.

Subject: Complaint — harm and lack of consent, [mine], Guinea.

"We petition [the financier's accountability mechanism] over [mine]: [harm done, consent absent], in breach of your safeguards. We ask for an investigation. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — To the buyers / on the "just transition".

Subject: Your 'clean' metal is dug from our ruin — [mine].

"The ore from [mine], sold into your supply chain and branded as feeding the green transition, is dug from farmland and water taken from our community: [specifics]. We ask you to press for it to be remedied. [Attach evidence.]"

8F — To an international watchdog / organisation.

Subject: Community harmed by [mine] — Guinea.

"Our community's farmland and water have been taken and fouled by [mine], run by [consortium] and financed by [lenders], in breach of their commitments. We've documented it. We ask for your help to reach the company, the financiers, and the buyers. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the (international) press.

Subject: The world's aluminium is dug from the ruin of Guinea's farmland.

"For generations the people of [place] farmed this land and drank this water. Now [mine] has taken and fouled them. We can provide documented harm, photographs, and a supply-chain map. [Contact.]"

8H — Uniting the community (carefully, honestly).

Subject: Consent and fair compensation — let's stand together.

"[Mine] has taken our farmland and water. Many of us hoped for jobs, and that's real — but not at the cost of our land and food. Let's insist together on genuine consent, fair compensation, and harm reduced, and reach the companies, financiers, and buyers who care about their name. Let's do it safely. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean — and safely — do these six things, in order:

- 1. Document the harm and the lack of consent — carefully, with dates and places.**
- 2. Insist on genuine consent and fair compensation (8A/8B).**
- 3. Map the supply chain — the company, its financiers, its buyers.**
- 4. Petition the financiers' accountability mechanism (8D) — a real, safer route.**
- 5. Press the company's own standards and the buyers' "clean" branding (8C/8E).**
- 6. Reach international watchdogs and press (8F/8G) — and mind your safety throughout.**

Even lean, those six reach up the supply chain and anchor on consent — the Guinean template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Guinea's field is badly tilted toward the mines, so plan for it — and for safety.

When the state is committed to the mines. Expect it — mining is the revenue. Reach the supply chain, the financiers, and the buyers, who sit beyond the state's reach and are sensitive to reputation.

When the community isn't united. Many hope for jobs. Frame the fight around consent, fair compensation, and harm reduced, not necessarily stopping all mining, to hold as much unity as you can.

When the space is constrained. Under a military transition, civil-society space is limited and confrontation is risky. Prioritise the international, financier, and supply-chain routes, which are both safer and often more effective, and protect those exposed.

When there's no precedent. This is a young, hard field. Build the case on the supply chain and consent, reach the reputation-conscious industries, and lay down the accountability that can grow into more.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Guinea has serious, documented problems with the capture of mining deals, so this matters — but tread carefully in a constrained space.

How to spot it. Agreements against the communities' interest; "consent" manufactured or coerced; compensation unpaid or pocketed; assessments written for the company; benefits to the connected while communities lose their land and water.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **transition government** has at times scrutinised the mining deals. The **financiers' accountability mechanisms** and **international watchdogs** can investigate and expose. And the **buyers** and reputation-conscious industries can strip legitimacy from a tainted supply chain.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — how consent was faked or coerced, how compensation went missing, who benefits — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. In a constrained space, route serious evidence to the financiers' mechanisms, international watchdogs, and trusted journalists rather than making risky public accusations, and protect those exposed. Pair the exposure with the supply-chain and consent case.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together, and safely. The documented harm and breach build your case; consent and compensation anchor it; a community united as far as it can be is the muscle; the company standards, the financiers, and the buyers press it up the supply chain; international watchdogs and press expose it. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and safety comes first throughout.

Early on (weeks 1–8): document the harm and the lack of consent; insist on consent and compensation; map the supply chain; root the fight in the community, honestly; build careful support and a safety plan.

In the thick of it (months–year+): petition the financiers' accountability mechanism; press the company's standards and the buyers' branding; reach international watchdogs and press.

The long haul (year+): carry the financier and supply-chain pressure; keep the coalition and the documentation ready; hold the line for consent and compensation honoured, harm reduced, water and farmland protected, a deal scrutinised, and accountability forced — keeping your people safe.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Defending land and water in Guinea is a fight without a landmark victory to point to — but not without levers, because the ore that devours the farmland flows out to the most reputation-conscious industries on earth. Hold both truths. The distinctive power here is real: the global companies bound by their own standards and reputations, the financiers whose accountability mechanisms communities can petition, the buyers and the "just transition" the metals are sold under, the requirement of genuine consent, and the transition government's scrutiny — levers that reach the mine from far up a global supply chain. And the constraints are real and large: a mining-dependent state, companies among the world's most powerful, poor and divided communities, a constrained and uncertain political space, and no precedent to follow.

Here's the discipline that wins what can be won — safely. Anchor on your rights: insist on genuine consent and fair compensation, and document every harm and every breach. Then reach up the supply chain: press the company's own human-rights and environmental standards and its reputation; petition the financiers' accountability mechanisms, a real and safer route; and challenge the buyers and the "just transition" branding a supply chain dug from ruin should not carry. Enlist international watchdogs and the global press, where the reputation-conscious industries are most exposed. Frame the fight around consent, compensation, and harm reduced to hold what unity you can, since many hope for jobs. And above all, in a constrained space, prioritise the international and supply-chain routes over risky confrontation, and keep your people safe. Count consent and compensation honoured, harm reduced, water and farmland protected, a deal scrutinised, and accountability forced as real wins — insisting that the metals the world needs not be dug from the ruin of communities' land and lives. That is the Guinean way — the supply chain, the financiers, and consent together, carried safely. So can you.